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SAMA SAATHI

Women-Led Community Digital Access Centres



Sama Digital Foundation
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Executive Summary

Sama Digital Foundation proposes to pilot its Sama Saathi programme in selected underserved communities.

The programme addresses two key gaps:

- **Access:** Limited availability of digital and essential services at the local level, particularly in underserved rural communities.
- **Livelihoods:** Limited opportunities for women to build sustainable livelihoods while serving as trusted digital facilitators within their communities.

Under the Sama Saathi model, a selected woman from the local community is supported to operate a **Sama Digi Kendra**, a community-level digital access point. **Sama Digital Foundation will provide:**

- **Refurbished corporate laptops** as the core technology infrastructure for each Sama Digi Kendra.
- **Centre setup support**, including relevant equipment and initial setup requirements.
- **Training** for the selected Saathis to operate and manage the centre.
- **Ongoing programme support**, including guidance, monitoring and handholding as the centres become operational.

A local implementation partner supports the identification and selection of suitable women, community mobilisation and local handholding. The devices deployed are refurbished end-of-life corporate laptops, which allows the programme to extend the working life of existing technology while improving digital access.

Background and Context

Digital access is increasingly important for citizens to access government services, applications, education, employment opportunities, welfare schemes and other essential services. However, access to a digital device alone does not necessarily translate into meaningful digital inclusion. In many underserved and remote communities, people may continue to face barriers related to distance, digital literacy, awareness, connectivity and the ability to navigate online processes.

In many rural and remote communities, people have to travel significant distances to access basic digital and government-related services. This adds time and travel costs and, particularly for daily-wage workers, can result in loss of income.

At the same time, there is an opportunity to build local capacity within these communities by supporting women who are willing to learn, operate a centre and provide useful digital services to people around them.

The Sama Saathi programme seeks to bring these two needs together by creating women-led local digital access points that combine technology, training, community demand and local support.

About Sama Digital Foundation

Sama Digital Foundation is an Indian non-profit incorporated in August 2024, and is the non-profit arm of NavGurukul, which has worked in technology education in India since 2016. Sama collects end-of-life laptops from corporate organisations, refurbishes them, and redeploys them with underserved women and youth.

To date, Sama has repurposed over 20,000 laptops, reaching more than 3.5 lakh people across 1,627 schools, working with 51 NGO partners in 22 states. The organisation holds CSR-1 registration and works with recognised e-waste channels for devices that cannot be restored.

About Sama Saathi

Sama Saathi is Sama Digital Foundation's women-led community digital access model. Sama works with local organisations and community networks to identify women who have the ability and willingness to operate a local digital centre.

The selected woman , the **Sama Saathi** , becomes the operator of a Sama Digi Kendra. Sama supports her with refurbished technology, training, programme resources and ongoing guidance, while the local partner helps her establish herself in the community and understand local demand.

The objective is not to distribute laptops to individual women. It is to create a locally operated community access point that provides useful digital services and generates a livelihood for the Saathi. The mix of services at each centre will depend on local demand, available partnerships and applicable permissions.

Early Experience: Sama Saathis in the Field

The Sama Saathi model is already being tested across different communities. The experiences of the early Saathis are helping Sama understand how women in different social and geographic contexts are using the centres to create livelihoods while providing services to their communities.

Shrutika | Yavatmal, Maharashtra

Shrutika is from Yavatmal and became a Sama Saathi while looking for an opportunity to support her family after the loss of her father. She now runs a local digital centre, using the refurbished laptop to provide digital services within her community while building an income for herself and her family.

Naina | Neemuch, Madhya Pradesh

Naina comes from the **Banchhada community in Madhya Pradesh**, a community where women have historically had limited access to stable livelihood opportunities and formal economic opportunities. Through the Sama Saathi model, Naina is building a local digital centre that gives her an opportunity to develop a livelihood while providing useful digital services within her own community.

Manisha | Nandurbar, Maharashtra

Manisha is a member of the local community in Nandurbar, Maharashtra, where she works closely with women and families in the region and is the sole earning member of her family. Through her Sama Digi Kendra, she has already begun providing digital services to people in her community and recently supported the registration of around **60 women farmers** (Mahila Kisan Pramaan Patra) , demonstrating the potential of the centre to connect local communities with important government services. She now hopes to further develop her centre and eventually expand it into a full CSC centre.

Nirmala | Gadchiroli, Maharashtra

Nirmala comes from a **remote, interior part of Gadchiroli**, where access to services and opportunities can be particularly difficult because of distance and geography. Her experience brings an important perspective to the Sama Saathi model: the value of having a trusted local woman who can help people access digital services closer to where they live.

Objectives of the Pilot

1. **Improve last-mile digital access.** Enable community members to reach digital services, information and opportunities closer to where they live, and build the skills of the women who deliver them.
2. **Create livelihood opportunities for women.** Enable selected women to operate local digital centres and develop income based on community demand and permitted services.
3. **Improve access to government-related services.** Understand how appropriately authorised centres can help community members navigate digital government processes, applications and information.
4. **Test whether the model works.** Run the model in selected districts, measure what happens, and use the evidence to decide whether it should be modified, expanded or discontinued.

Proposed Partnership Model

Role of Sama Digital Foundation

1. Providing refurbished corporate laptops and the equipment required for the centre model agreed for each location.
2. Supporting the setup of the Sama Digi Kendra.
3. Training selected Saathis in digital tools, centre operations and the programme's service components, and providing operating materials and ongoing mentoring.
4. Retaining ownership of the equipment, which the Saathi holds in custody under a written agreement between Sama, the field partner and the Saathi, with device tracking maintained throughout.
5. Monitoring centre performance and programme outcomes
6. Working with government and local partners to refine the model through the pilot period.

Role of the Ground Implementation Partner

The ground partner provides the local implementation and community-support layer. A suitable partner would have an established presence in the target geography and a working understanding of the community. Their responsibilities include:

1. Identifying women who may be suitable to become Sama Saathis, and supporting screening and selection.
2. Assessing whether the proposed location and community are suitable.
3. Supporting community mobilisation and awareness about the centre.
4. Helping the Saathi build standing within the community.
5. Providing regular local handholding, and raising operational problems with Sama.
6. Supporting continuity if a Saathi is unable to continue, so that the centre and equipment remain in use for the intended purpose.

The ground partner's role matters most in the first few months, when the Saathi is still building both her operating capability and her credibility locally.

Role of the Sama Saathi

The Saathi is the operator of the centre and its community-facing face. She will:

1. Operate and maintain the Sama Digi Kendra, and keep basic records of usage and activity.
2. Provide digital facilitation and services within the scope of her training and applicable permissions.
3. Help community members access online information and services, and build awareness of schemes, opportunities and applications relevant to them.
4. Encourage women, youth and other community members to use the centre.
5. Participate in training, and develop income-generating activity connected to the centre within the services permitted.

Services through the Centre

1. Digital and government-related services: Assistance with services such as Services at each Sama Digi Kendra will be based on local demand, available partnerships and applicable permissions. The initial services may include:

- **Government documentation:** PAN, Passport, Jeevan Pramaan Patra, Farmar ID, GST, ITR and insurance-related services.
- **Digital and financial services:** FASTag, utility payments and Aadhaar-based biometric transactions.
- **B2C services:** Printing, scanning, photocopying and digital design.

2. Information and access support: Help with navigating online government portals, schemes, programmes, applications and other digital processes that may otherwise be difficult for community members to access independently.

3. Education and employment support: Access to online learning resources, scholarships, examinations, job and recruitment applications, and other relevant opportunities.

4. Local livelihood and digital support: Basic digital support for local entrepreneurs, small businesses and women-led enterprises, where relevant to the community.